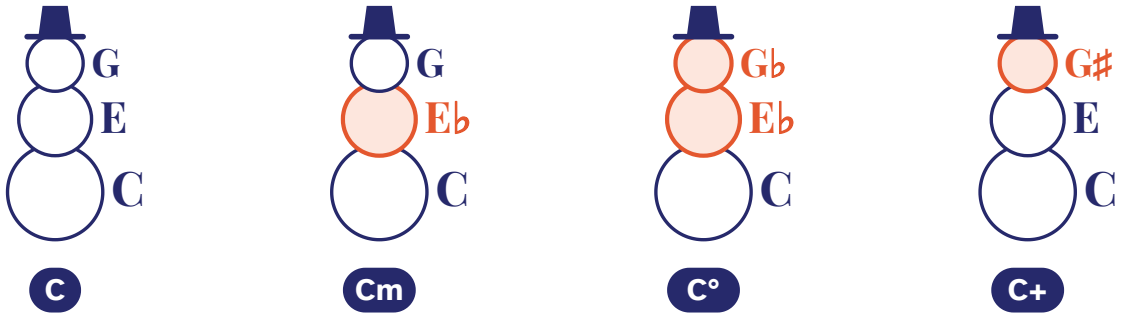
PART IV · CHORDS · 2

Four kinds of triad

Every triad is two 3rds stacked. To tell the kinds apart, count the keys **in between**, black and white, that you do not play: root to 3rd, then 3rd to 5th. Those two numbers name the kind, and its sound.

THE SECRET

Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor.

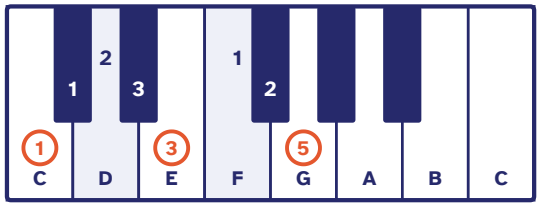


Count the keys between: 3 + 2 is major, 2 + 3 is minor

KIND	KEYS BETWEEN	ON C	CHORD NAME	FIRST MET
major	**3 + 2**	C E G	C	Level ½
minor	**2 + 3**	C E♭ G	Cm	Level 2
diminished	**2 + 2**	C E♭ G♭	C° or Cdim	Level 5
augmented	**3 + 3**	C E G♯	C+ or Caug	Level 6

Chord names: a letter alone means major (C); m means minor (Cm). You see them above the melody in songbooks and lead sheets: C | Am | F | G. In interval names, 3 keys between is a major 3rd and 2 is a minor 3rd (p. 40).

Count the keys in between



Play C and E and count the keys you skip, black and white: C♯, D, D♯ is **3**. Then E to G: F, F♯ is **2**. **3 + 2 is major.** Any root works the same way: from D, skip 3 to F♯, then 2 to A: D F♯ A, D major.

PART IV · CHORDS · 2 · CONTINUED

The seven white-key triads, sorted



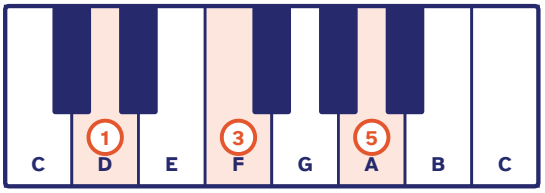
Always the same on the white keys: **three major** (C, F, G), **three minor** (D, E, A), **one diminished** (B), no augmented. In any major key, chords I, IV and V are the major ones (p. 92).

How they sound

KIND	SOUNDS	HEARD IN
major	bright, settled, open	most cheerful tunes, fanfares
minor	darker, softer, sadder	lullabies, laments, film tension
diminished	tense, unstable, wants to move	suspense, the chord before home
augmented	floating, dreamy, unsettled	dream scenes, a passing colour

EXAMPLE 1

Major or minor? D F A



1 **Root to 3rd:** D to F skips D♯ and E: **2**.

2 **3rd to 5th:** F to A skips F♯, G and G♯: **3**.

3 **2 + 3** is minor.

D F A is **D minor** (Dm). Three of the white-key triads are minor: D, E and A.

GAME

Which kind?



1 2 3

Count the keys between: 3 + 2 major, 2 + 3 minor, 2 + 2 diminished, 3 + 3 augmented.

Answer: 1 diminished · 2 major · 3 augmented.

PART IV · CHORDS · 2 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



C E G, then C E♭ G, then C E♭ G♭.

Bright, dark, tense. Only the middle ball moves first, then the top one. Listen for the change each time.

EXAMPLE 2

Build a triad on B
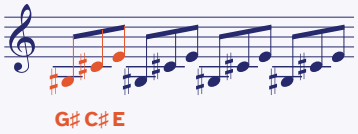


1. **Skip a letter:** B, D, F.
2. **Count the keys between:** B to D, 2 (C, C♯); D to F, 2 (D♯, E).
3. **2 + 2:** diminished.

B D F is **B diminished** (B°): the only diminished triad on the white keys.

YOU KNOW THIS

Beethoven, Moonlight Sonata (first movement)



The famous slow triplets are the notes of a **C♯ minor triad**: C♯, E and G♯, rocking gently. Minor is why it sounds so dark and sad.

THINK OF IT Two floors of a building: a tall floor (3 keys between) and a short one (2). Major: tall, then short, 3 + 2. Minor: short, then tall, 2 + 3. Diminished: two short, 2 + 2. Augmented: two tall, 3 + 3.

TRAP

- × Counting the keys you play: count only the keys in between, black and white.
- × Forgetting that in diminished and augmented triads the 5th changes too.
- × Spelling with the wrong letter: a triad skips one letter, so C minor is C E♭ G, never C D♯ G.

SEE ALSO
Chords and triads p. 86 · Major, minor and perfect p. 40

PRACTISE IT
Workbook Harmony 2 · Online: Library › Chords